Executive Summary

Our analysis looked at concrete ingredients, specifically how their curing time relates to compressive strength. This was so that we could help make more informed design and production decisions. With 1030 concrete samples, we used 900 for our training dataset and 130 for our testing set. We used 8 predictors to account for different ingredient mixes and environmental factors.

Our best model explained roughly 75% of the variation of concrete strength in the testing data (in comparison, the original model explained like 35%). It performed even better on the testing samples, explaining about 80% of the variation.

Overall, concrete strength correlated with multiple features, including cement, water, blast furnace slag and curing time. Thus it was a good decision to look at the complete formulation rather than just relying on any singular ingredient. We recommend using our final model to screen new proposed concrete formulations to see if they're promising enough for physical testing.

Problem Context & Data Overview

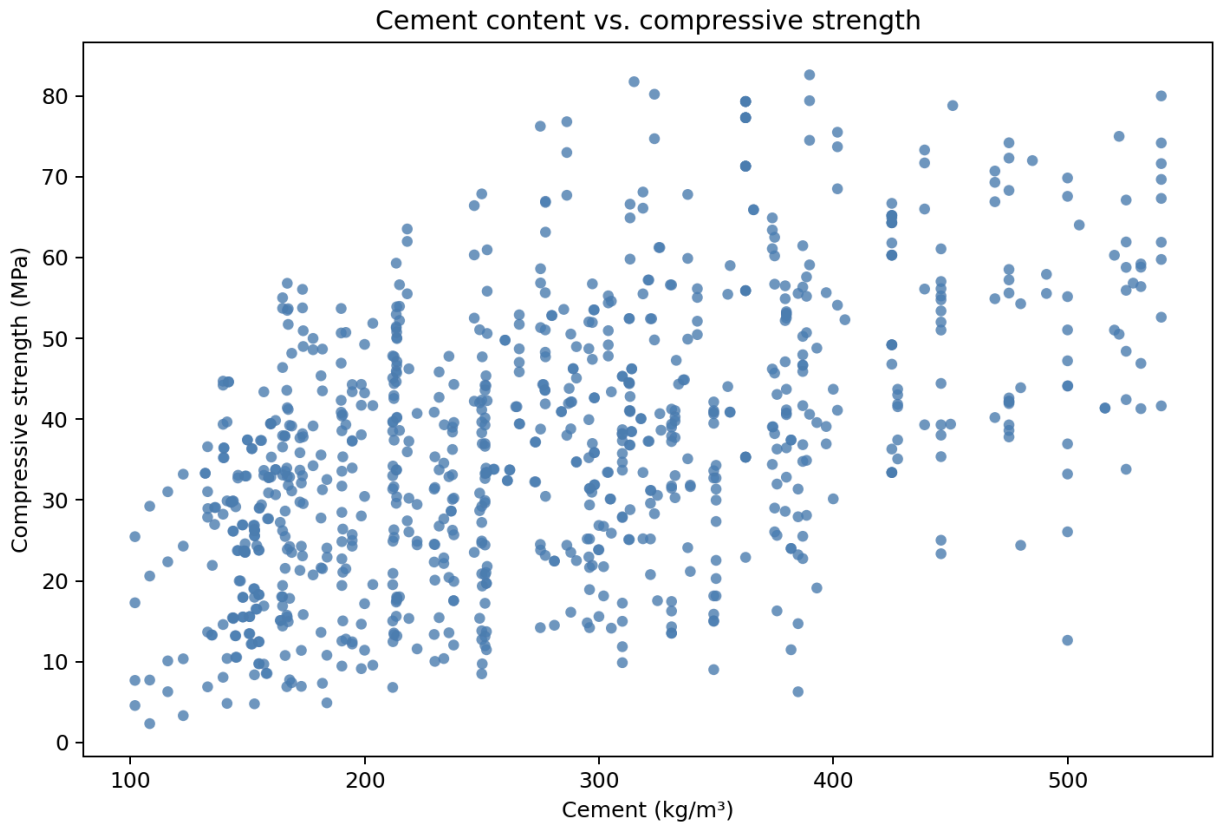
This analysis looks at 8 features of a concrete mix (cement, blast furnace slag, fly ash water, superplasticizer, course aggregate, fine aggregate, age) and looks at how they affect concrete strength, measured by how much pressure it can take before it fails. These relationships let us understand what kinds of mixtures are promising to test, and how they hold up over time.

Of our 1030 observations, we used 900 for training. Below are aggregate statistics collected from the training dataset:

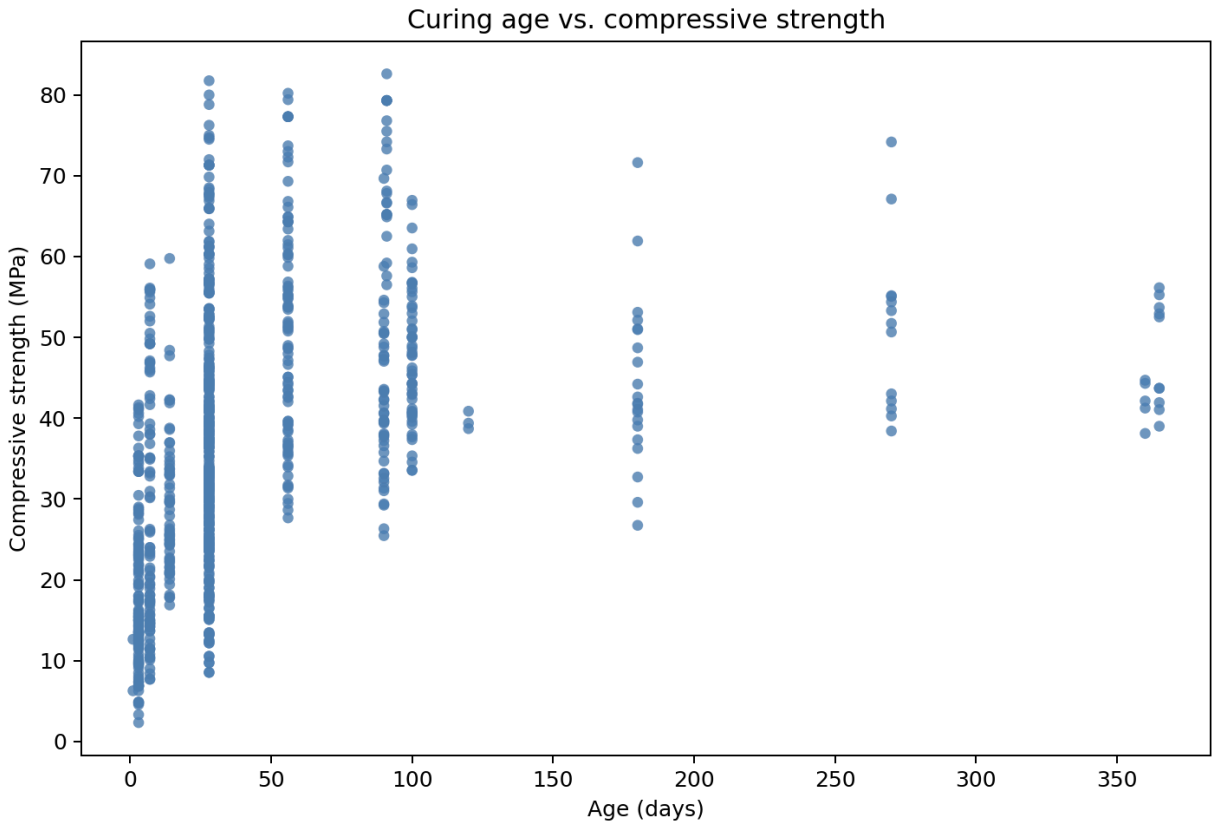
Variable	Mean	Standard deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Cement (kg/m³)	278.16	106.22	102.00	540.00
Blast furnace slag (kg/m³)	76.14	84.05	0.00	305.30
Fly ash (kg/m³)	57.52	64.27	0.00	200.10

Water (kg/m³)	180.74	22.29	121.80	247.00
Superplasticizer (kg/m³)	6.87	5.98	0.00	32.20
Coarse aggregate (kg/m³)	973.44	77.59	801.00	1,145.00
Fine aggregate (kg/m³)	772.18	81.92	594.00	992.60
Age (days)	46.04	61.32	1.00	365.00
Compressive strength (MPa)	36.97	16.65	2.33	82.60

We also analyzed how individual features correlate with concrete strength. The chart below shows a weak positive correlation between cement content and strength.



Additionally, we looked at the relationship between curing age and concrete strength, but it didn't seem like there was much of a correlation.



It is clear that there can be drastic variation in strength among concrete mixes of the same cement content or age, showing that one must consider many features holistically in order to more accurately gauge strength.

Model Reliability & Analytical Findings

The final model explained around 80% of the variation in strength among training samples, and around 75% of the variation among testing samples. Since it performed similarly across the two groups, we can conclude it learned relationships that remained useful for samples it hadn't seen during development. However, since the model can't explain all of the variation in strength, we suggest supplementing its predictions with physical testing.

The final model log-transforms the inputs, which significantly improved performance compared to the original model. We also tried standardizing the inputs, but it did not lead to any change compared to the original. See the results in the below chart.

Model	Training R^2	Testing R^2	Testing MSE (MPa^2)
Original inputs	0.624	0.351	141.26
Standardized inputs	0.624	0.351	141.26
Log-transformed inputs	0.799	0.750	54.52

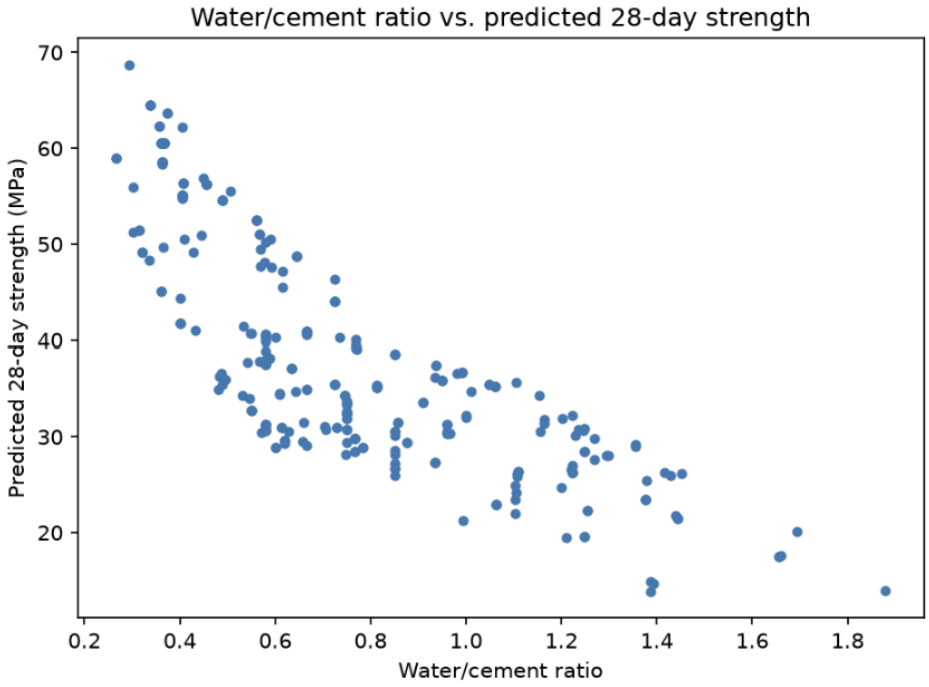
The original model provides straightforward relationships between ingredient quantities and predicted strength. For example (holding other predictors constant), an additional 10 kg/m^3 of cement was associated with around 1.33 MPa higher strength. The log scaled model has more complex relationships, but in this case, that allowed it to have more accurate predictions in general.

For practical use, the final model is a useful datapoint for comparing concrete formulations. Its testing root mean squared error is around 7.4 MPa, so individual predictions can still vary from the measured strength. Before using predictions to guide operational changes, the organization should do physical trials and compare the results.

Strategic Recommendations & Implementation Plan

One recommendation would be that since the p-values of the Cement and Age features are extremely low across all the different models we tested and their coefficients in the untransformed model are positive, that adding a higher proportion of cement as well as simply waiting longer for the concrete to set is an effective method to increase concrete strength. Another recommendation would be to test mixtures with a higher proportion of blast furnace slag, since its coefficient is positive and its p-value is also consistently low across all models. If slag is cheaper than cement, partial cement replacement could reduce costs, provided strength tests confirm that the mix still meets the required strength. Finally, we tested a variety of water/cement ratios across randomly sampled values of the other features, and found their predicted strength according to our best model. This illustrates that generally, our model predicts that 28-day strength increases with decreased water/cement ratio, so an actionable suggestion would be to decrease the amount of water proportional to cement as long as the mixture still holds and while

minimizing costs, in order to maximize the strength of the concrete in the long run.



We acknowledge that there are many potential limitations of our current model. One is the possibility that certain relevant environmental factors are not accounted for, such as temperature or humidity, which could affect concrete strength and cause extra variance that is not able to be accounted for in the training data. A more risk-averse model could be made if more potentially relevant features were tested and evaluated to see if they improve model performance (decided first by consulting with an expert engineer). Our testing of models could also incorporate cross-validation, to ensure that we aren't overfitting by optimizing for the one specific set of testing data that we initially chose. Also, a linear regression model may not be able to account for all the patterns in the data. This can be mitigated in future model improvements by incorporating nonlinear features, for example a water/cement ratio, or by using nonlinear models such as random forests or polynomial regression.

Finally, one way to ensure our model stays relevant and accurate over long periods of time is implementing a continuous monitoring framework. The first step would be that whenever a construction team affiliated with the project creates a new concrete mix, they should set aside a small portion of that mix for testing. The set-aside mix can then be used to form multiple concrete samples, which can be tested for strength on different days to get multiple training examples with varying ages from just one new mix. The results (the proportion of materials used as well as the age of the concrete mix) can then be logged using a customized data entry system or into a spreadsheet. This can

then be hooked up to a database, and on the backend, we can evaluate the current model's performance on the new entries as well as use the new entries to retrain/refine the existing model to hopefully better fit future concrete mixes. We can do this by training newer models on only a center number of the most recent samples, so that the model is able to adapt to changing conventions in material composition and other changes that might make a model only trained on historical concrete data obsolete.